

IELTS Writing Common Mistakes Pack

Book 4 of 5 · Fix the errors that keep scores stuck

Stratum IELTS · stratumielts.com

Edition 2026 · Original content

Part of the Stratum IELTS Writing Guide Series

Series map

#	Book	Focus
1	Task 2 Structure Pack	Essay structure
2	Task 1 Charts Pack	Academic reports
3	Band 7 Vocabulary Pack	Vocabulary
4	Common Mistakes Pack (this book)	Error repair
5	Essay Checklist Mini	Final checks

How to use this book

1. Read one mistake family at a time.
2. Rewrite the “wrong → right” examples in your notebook.
3. In your next essay, hunt only for that error type.
4. After two weeks, review all families with Book 5.

Most learners do not need more tips. They need fewer repeated mistakes.

Contents

1. Task response mistakes
 2. Structure and cohesion mistakes
 3. Grammar hotspots
 4. Vocabulary mistakes
 5. Task 1-specific mistakes
 6. Repair drills
 7. Next step
-

1. Task response mistakes

Mistake 1: Not answering the exact question

Wrong focus: writing generally about “education” when asked about *free university*.

Fix: underline task words; answer them in the introduction.

Mistake 2: No clear position

Weak: *There are pros and cons.* (and never choosing)

Stronger: *Although there are drawbacks, I believe...*

Mistake 3: Missing one part of a two-part question

Fix: label parts A/B in your outline and check both appear in body paragraphs.

Mistake 4: Ideas without support

Weak: *Online learning is good for students.*

Stronger: *Online learning helps students in remote areas because they can attend classes without relocating.*

Mistake 5: Memorised essay that does not fit

Examiners notice off-topic memorised content. Adapt templates; do not force an old essay onto a new question.

2. Structure and cohesion mistakes

Mistake 6: Introduction too long

Keep intro to 2–3 sentences. Save development for body paragraphs.

Mistake 7: One paragraph = many unrelated ideas

Fix: one paragraph, one central idea.

Mistake 8: Overusing linking words

Weak: *Firstly, moreover, furthermore, additionally, besides...* in every sentence.

Fix: use links only when the relationship needs them.

Mistake 9: Conclusion with new ideas

No new arguments in the final paragraph. Restate and summarise only.

Mistake 10: Unclear reference words

Weak: *This makes it better.* (What is *this/it*?)

Stronger: *This policy makes public transport more attractive.*

3. Grammar hotspots

Mistake 11: Articles (*a / an / the*)

- *Education is important.* (general, no article)
- *The education system in my country...* (specific)

Mistake 12: Subject–verb agreement

- *The number of cars has increased.*
- *People have different opinions.*

Mistake 13: Countable / uncountable

- *information* (not *informations*)
- *advice* (not *advices*)
- *research* (not *researches* as a plural noun in this sense)

Mistake 14: Tense inconsistency in Task 1

Past charts → past tense.

Timeless processes → present simple.

Mistake 15: Run-on sentences

Weak: *Cities are crowded they need better transport.*

Stronger: *Cities are crowded, so they need better transport.*

Mistake 16: Fragment sentences

Every sentence needs a clear subject + verb idea.

Mistake 17: Passive voice overuse with no purpose

Passive is fine in Task 1 processes; in Task 2, prefer clear active sentences unless the actor is unimportant.

4. Vocabulary mistakes

Mistake 18: Forced rare words

Weak: *The predicament of metropolitan inhabitants is multifaceted...*

Stronger: *City residents face several serious problems...*

Mistake 19: Wrong collocations

Wrong	Right
do a decision	make a decision
discuss about	discuss
increase of people happiness	an increase in people's happiness
nowadays people	nowadays, people... (comma / cleaner rewrite: <i>Today, people...</i>)

Mistake 20: Informal tone

Avoid: *kids, guys, stuff, a lot of* (prefer *children, people, issues, many/a large number of* carefully).

Mistake 21: Repeating the question wording exactly

Paraphrase key phrases in the introduction, then use natural topic words.

Mistake 22: Absolute claims

Avoid *always / never / all people* unless clearly true. Prefer *often / many / in some cases*.

5. Task 1-specific mistakes

Mistake 23: No overview

Always include a clear overview of main trends/differences.

Mistake 24: Listing every number

Select key features; group data.

Mistake 25: Personal opinion in Task 1

Do not explain *why* society caused the trend unless the task asks (it usually does not).

Mistake 26: Inaccurate data

Never invent figures. If unsure, use *approximately* only when the chart supports it.

6. Repair drills

Drill A — Fix task response

Rewrite this intro so it takes a clear position:

Some people say unpaid work should be required at school. There are advantages and disadvantages to this idea.

Drill B — Fix grammar

Correct:

1. These informations are useful.
2. The percentage of students have risen.
3. In 2010 the figure increase to 40%.

Drill C — Fix cohesion

Split into two clear sentences and improve references:

Online shopping is popular this makes local shops struggle they cannot offer the same prices.

Drill D — Real essay repair

Take one old essay and highlight every error from this book. Fix only those. Then resubmit at stratumielts.com.

7. Next step

- Rebuild structure → **Book 1**
- Task 1 method → **Book 2**
- Stronger wording → **Book 3**
- Final pass before submit → **Book 5**

Repeated mistakes fall fastest when you fix **one family per practice day**.

Get scored feedback: <https://stratumielts.com>

About this booklet

Published by **Stratum IELTS** · stratumielts.com

Original examples and explanations · Edition 2026 · Personal study use

Independent IELTS study resource.

End of Book 4 — Common Mistakes Pack · stratumielts.com